ACER INDIA

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26 Years of Making Technology Accessible

From Vision to Scale: Harish Kohli's Enduring Impact on Acer India



As India Today marks five decades of documenting the nation's transformation, Acer India reflects on 26 years of enabling digital access and shaping how technology integrates into everyday Indian life under the leadership of Harish Kohli.

When Acer India was incorporated in 1999, personal computing was largely confined to urban centers. The world was bracing for Y2K, the dot-com wave was gathering momentum, and India was on the brink of a digital awakening. Enter Acer, embarking on a journey that would closely parallel India's own technological evolution—bringing computing out of boardrooms and into classrooms, homes, and small businesses across tier-2 and tier-3 markets.

Under the visionary leadership of Harish Kohli, President and Managing Director, whose long association with the brand has shaped its India story, Acer has grown to make India its second-largest market globally. More importantly, the brand has evolved from a PC company into a comprehensive technology ecosystem—spanning AI-powered laptops, education solutions, enterprise infrastructure, and fast-growing lifestyle electronics and appliances.

"Technology today is not just about cutting-edge innovation—it's about relevance, adaptability, and impact," Kohli notes, articulating a philosophy that has guided Acer's transformation. This thinking has driven several early bets: expanding computing access in education, enabling flexible form factors for modern users, and identifying gaming and high-performance computing as powerful cultural and economic forces long before they entered the mainstream.

Acer's commitment to accessibility is most visible in how deeply it has penetrated India beyond metros. Educational institutions across the country rely on Acer solutions to power digital classrooms and learning labs, while a strong physical retail presence ensures trust and reach in emerging markets. This focus on Bharat has made technology more approachable, reliable, and aspirational for millions of first-time users.

Recognizing that technology was becoming deeply embedded in everyday life, Acer expanded into consumer appliances through Acerpure, extending its core strengths of engineering, reliability, and design into categories such as air treatment, home appliances, and lifestyle electronics. Rather than approaching appliances as a volume-led business, Acerpure was built with a clear philosophy: applying technology-led thinking to improve health, comfort, and quality of life. This move positioned Acer not just inside offices and classrooms, but within Indian homes—making the brand relevant across daily touchpoints.

Parallelly, Acer strengthened its datacenter and cloud footprint through Altos, its servers and workstations business. As India's digital backbone evolved—driven by cloud adoption, data-led governance, and enterprise modernization—Altos emerged as a critical enabler of backend infrastructure. From data centers and public sector digitization to AI-led workloads and high-performance computing, the focus has been on delivering robust, scalable, and locally relevant infrastructure solutions that power India's digital ambitions behind the scenes.

Accessibility at Acer goes beyond products. Initiatives such as Visionova, which supports children with visual impairment, and "Heal On Wheels," delivering healthcare access to underserved communities, underscore the belief that innovation must serve society. "The true measure of technology," Kohli believes, "is the positive change it enables."

Today, Acer India's journey reflects a broader ambition. With local manufacturing initiatives, the rapid growth across IT< consumer electronics and appliances, the expansion in enterprise servers and workstations, and leadership in AI-driven computing and esports, Acer continues to align closely with India's growth story. From rural classrooms to smart homes, from AI creators to competitive gamers, Acer's presence has not merely accompanied India's digital rise—it has actively shaped it, one accessible innovation at a time.